Monday Nite Footballers Predictions

By Jim Nunnelly

Kansas City Chiefs vs. Denver Broncos

Sunday, August 31

Mile High Stadium, 3 p.m.

Denver, Colorado

KCFX 101/KSHB-TV 41

Member	Prediction	Comments
Allen, Dr. Charles	Chiefs by 7	Optimistic
Booker, Paul	Denver by 6	KC still in preseason
Clark, Carl	Denver by 10	KC too many rookies
Gardner, Ike	Denver by 10	Too busy to comment
Greenfield, Lloyd	Denver by 10	Denver more precise
Hubbard, Ollie	Denver by 20	Mile High anger
Livingston, Walt	Chiefs by6	KC will play bigtime
Nunnelly, Jim	Denver by many	Neil's revenge
Sypert, Harry	Denver by 10	JOHN!
West, Ed	Denver by 6	Chiefs aren't ready yet

Commentary, Conversation and Chatter

The Derrick vs. Neil Friendship

This game on Sunday is not about the Chiefs and their many new faces. And it's not about the Chiefs' flimsy, questionable offensive line.

It's not even about Elway and his 26-touchdown pass season last year. Neither is it about Shannon Sharpe, Denver's All-Pro tight end, who caught 80 of Elway's bullets for 10 scores.

This game is about the special friendship Derrick Thomas and Neil Smith shared before the salary cap reality set in.

It all started about a decade ago, when Neil Smith showed up from Nebraska and Derrick Thomas came in from Alabama. One a tough, defensive lineman and the other a quick-of-foot linebacker. They didn't know each other and they only would have the red and white uniform in common. But, they lined up together, talked a lot and went on to become the most feared sack duo in the entire National Football League, racking up 182 sacks together. Most of all, they became real good friends, even making a famous telephone long distance commercial together. Powerfully protective, and inseparable friendship, on and off the football field.

That is until the divisive, third party, impersonal salary cap entered. Last year, Derrick asked for and received a big contract from the front office. He even lobbied for his partner in crime, Neil Smith. The front office said no and sent Neil off to Denver to play for the Broncos. In the process, a wall had been built between the superstars.

But come this Sunday, that wall will come tumbling down. Derrick and Neil will line up on different sides, kind of like brother against brother. And for the first time in their starlike, professional careers. Though they won't be on the field at the same time, they will battle each other in a different way.

Derrick will be chasing Denver quarterback John Elway. And Neil will be giving untested and untried Elvis Grbac a fit. Each watching and respecting each other. In spite of other buildups, this game will be about how many times Derrick gets to Elway and how many times Neil gets to Grbac. And they'll be counting, too. It'll be the "falcon" defense put on by Derrick against the post-sack homerun display, coined by Neil Smith when he was here in Kansas City.

And after the game, they'll meet and greet at midfield. They'll laugh, joke and talk and even hug. You'll see Neil stretch out one of those long arms and you'll see Derrick with that innocent, disarming smile. And we will all know that in spite of salary caps and short sighted front offices, that the Derrick versus Neil friendship is still intact.

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